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Mystical Twin Towns

While plausible speculations or explanations have been provided for a couple of twin-riddled towns, there are some that are still covered in a complete shroud of mystery

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wins are a beguiling phenomenon and it is often perceived that not all regions in the world are created

equally when it comes to twin birthing. According to the University of Texas researchers, 32 individuals or 16 pairs out of every 1,000 people in this world are twins, which roughly translates to about three per cent of the human population. This figure seems to vary greatly depending on region, race and ethnicity.

Until the year 2011, scientists had a very disjunctive picture of the twinning rates around the world since reliable information about this phenomenon was only documented efficiently in developed countries that had good birth registrations. Data from underdeveloped or developing countries were often lacking in authenticity and accuracy. However, scientists and researchers joined forces in 2011 to create elabo-

rate twin databases for 76 developing countries. The databases were created by aggregating data on approximately 2.5 million births by 1.4 million women between the years 1987 and 2010. An average of 13.6 pairs of twins being born every 1,000 births were recorded.

According to research conducted by scientists from Radboud University and Oxford University, Central Africa currently snags the record for the highest twinning rate in the world - more than 18 pairs per 1,000 births, while Asia and Latin America are recorded as having some of the lowest twinning rates across the globe - less than eight pairs per 1,000 births. Over the last few years, a few towns have come into prominence due to their inordinately high twinning rates, and the inability, sometimes, to scientifically explain the cause of this vast disparity. Let's delve into the mystical twin twins across the globe that have incited research and even baffled scientists worldwide.

IGBO-ORA, NIGERIA

Situated around 80 kilometres north of Lagos State in Nigeria, a town named Igbo-Ora, dubbed as "The Twin Capital of the World", usually boasts at least one set of twins per household! Sporting unusually high twinning birth rates, a study was undertaken by an English gynaecologist, Patrick Nylander, which



Image credit: Reuters

Twin town, Igbo-Ora in Nigeria is known as the Twin Capital of the World.

indicated that an average of 45 to 50 sets of twins per 1,000 live births was recorded in the curious little town. That is nearly 10 per cent of the population! Recent reports suggest that the number is closer to 150 sets of twins every 1,000 live births, which is inconceivable really. Research by fertility experts at the Lagos University Teaching Hospital looking

into this unconventional phenomenon suggested that the widely consumed tuber (yams) eaten by the local women may have resulted in the high twinning rates. This is because the natural hormone phytoestrogen, which is present in high quantities in these particular yams, often stimulates the ovaries to release eggs from both sides. While this has not been empirically proven, it is still a valid hypothesis as suggested by multiple researchers and scientists. However, the leader of the Igbo-

FUN FACT

Since twins are so common in the town of Igbo-Ora, they are usually given specific names - Taiwo or Kehinde, depending on which twin is born first. So, there are just multiple Taiwos and Kehindes strolling around this mysterious town.